

ARUN KUMAR

THE REVIVAL Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge poses with the Gandhis after a party meeting, Jun. 8

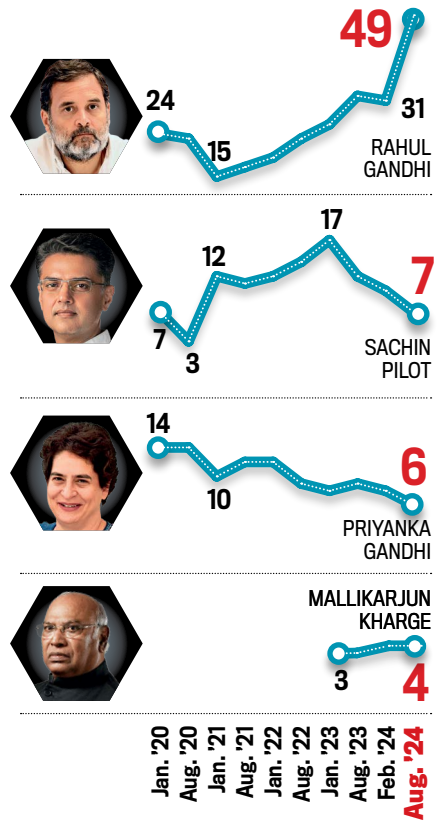
from 17.4 per cent during the same period. This decline underscores a possible consolidation around Rahul, but also suggests a lack of compelling alternatives within the Opposition.

Even Rahul's approval ratings are not without caveats; 24.2 per cent respondents rated his performance as poor, reflecting a polarised view. Nearly one-fourth of upper-caste Hindu respondents rated his performance as very poor, hinting at the underlying caste dynamics. His relentless demand for a caste census may have added to his popularity but, conversely, also alienated him from the upper caste population who see it as a challenge to their socio-political dominance.

POLITY AND FAMILY

One of the central themes in Rahul's political discourse has been uplifting the poor and downtrodden. In the process, he has at times rightly or wrongly targeted high-income groups such as industrialists and business magnates. Ironically, he has better approval ratings among respondents from the higher income group with 29 per cent rating his performance as outstanding compared to 21 per cent from lower income groups.

Q. Which Congress leader is best suited to revive the party?



All figures in % and rounded off

Rahul is unequivocally the party's No. 1 leader now

The survey also delves into the public opinion on Priyanka Gandhi, whose entry into active electoral politics has been a subject of much speculation and analysis. When asked who was a better politician among the two siblings, 54.8 per cent respondents favoured Rahul, while 17.3 per cent supported Priyanka. This wide margin suggests that despite her charisma and public appeal, Priyanka still has a long way to go in eclipsing her brother in the public eye as a political leader. Rahul's dominance within the Congress is further underscored with nearly half (48.6 per cent) of the respondents backing him as the best person suited to lead the party, a significant jump from 31.1 per cent in February.

When queried about the impact of Priyanka's entry into electoral politics, 41.2 per cent of the respondents believed it would boost the Congress, while 22.3 per cent said it would have no impact. Interestingly, 10.4 per cent felt it would create two power centres within the party, a scenario that could potentially lead to internal friction. These responses reflect an ambivalence towards Priyanka's role, with a significant portion of the electorate unsure about her potential to galvanise the Congress.